those foolish Italians who didn't even know how to have real money. Eighteen thousand lire sounded like a lot, but it came out to $7.20. Those were terrific times for Americans, but they're gone forever.

Today, of course, investors accept the fact that the United States is one country among many, the dollar is one currency among many, and the U.S. stock market is one stock market among many. Ours may still be the largest market—though for a short spell in the late 1980s the Japanese market, ridiculously inflated, was bigger in total capitalization terms—but we sure as heck aren't the only one.

Somewhere back in the sixties and seventies, Europe began to get its act together, Japan became a powerhouse, and Southeast Asia began filling up with bustling workshops, so that Korea, Taiwan, Hong Kong, Singapore, Malaysia, and Indonesia turned into important manufacturing centers. About 1985 I realized that many of the U.S. companies I owned were getting their asses kicked by some hustler in Hong Kong who was turning out a quality rival product at a lower price. I started hearing all kinds of stories from my companies: "We had to close down our factory in Kentucky because somebody's bringing up stuff from Guatemala that we can't compete with."

As a Chicago Cubs fan, I had long realized you can love losers, but it is not a wise idea to bet on them. (I don't know why people worry about the Cubs. As some sage has noted, anybody can have a bad century once in a while.)

Bet on good companies regardless of what country they're domiciled in.

I figured we had better start looking at some of these foreign companies. My motto became "Don't bitch; switch."